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GFN1000 In Dialogue with Nature

18th Feb 2024

Walking Out of the Cave

Plato and Aristotle are the two leading renowned figures of ancient Greek science and philosophy, and their perception of science is the cornerstone of modern science. In our textbook, we introduced Plato's ideas first. I highly approve of this arrangement because it is a better way to guide the students into reflecting on nature and science.

Firstly, the early introduction of Plato's ideas in our course is a captivating and thought-provoking experience for students.

In Plato's work "*Republic*," he masterfully constructs an allegory—the famous "cave" metaphor. Imagine a cave where prisoners have been fettered since birth. Their only perception of reality comes from the shadows cast on the cave wall by puppeteers manipulating objects behind them. To the prisoners, these shadows constitute the entirety of their world—their "reality."

But Plato challenges this illusion. He posits that outside the cave lies a broader, more profound truth—an "intelligible realm." In this realm, the changeless and perfect forms transcend mere sensory perceptions. It exists independently of shadows and illusions. Here, truth is not distorted by flickering light or deceptive reflections.

This highly visual and vivid scenario resonates with students. It stirs our curiosity and compels us to reflect on the nature of knowledge, perception, and our hunger for deeper understanding. The truth behind the “cave” metaphor is just as shocking as if we were watching “The Matrix” and suddenly realized that the Matrix world is merely a virtual construct. In contrast, humans have unwittingly become puppets controlled by machines in the real world. After contemplating the “cave” metaphor, students like me also recognize the essential role of education. During our primary and middle school years, we often view teachers as our introductory guides, absorbing their teachings with unwavering trust. However, upon entering university, a shift occurs. We realize that we must actively lead ourselves through the gradual process of understanding the world. Plato’s wisdom resonates here: we start by glimpsing the images reflected in water, then observe the sky and night, and finally, we encounter the sun’s illuminating light.

Consider our pre-college education in subjects like math and physics. While we learn foundational concepts, there are gaps—advanced knowledge like calculus remains unexplored. Our perception of the world becomes akin to observing shadows cast by puppets on a cave wall—a mere fraction of reality. But advanced tools, such as calculus, extend toward the cave exit, bridging the gap between our limited understanding and the vastness of reality.

Higher education becomes our beacon. Teachers guide us, not as puppeteers manipulating our perceptions, but as mentors illuminating the path out of the cave. They empower us to enter the light. Yet, we must strike a balance—neither relying solely on teachers nor dismissing their wisdom entirely.

By introducing Plato at the beginning of our GFN course, we establish a correct idea of the relationship between teachers and students in our GE courses and

our university. This realization is essential; students should know it as early as possible.

University teachers are like guides. They help students explore knowledge, raise questions, and think critically. Like sailors steering us away from misinformation and toward understanding. But remember, we hold the reins. We can stay in the cave of limited knowledge or step into the brilliance of unlimited truths.

Also, by introducing Plato first, students will reflect on the essence of the world, philosophy, and science. This arrangement encourages their minds to explore various domains rather than focusing solely on “science” initially. As we continue our studies, we will gradually recognize the significant influence of Plato’s theories on the development of the scientific field.

The arrangement also has temporal coherence because Plato was Aristotle’s teacher, and Plato’s ideas greatly inspired Aristotle.

According to Brian Duignan, a senior editor at Encyclopedia Britannica, Aristotle eventually departed from Plato’s philosophy in some essential parts. While Plato tended to devalue the world of the senses (but not wholly), Aristotle’s approach was more empirical and practical. Also, Aristotle’s investigations into philosophy and scientific fields expanded beyond Plato’s focus, leading to significant contributions to science. His cosmology, mathematical description of motion and dynamics, etc., significantly contributed to the development of Newtonian science.

In conclusion, I support introducing Plato first in our GFN course because it not only enhances the logical coherence of the course but also makes it an actual lantern in the cave, which sparks our curiosity, urging us to question shadows and seek more profound truths. We carry Plato's wisdom as we further in dialogue with nature. We strive to walk out of the cave!

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